

THE \$5K-\$10K ANIMATED WEBSITE PLAYBOOK

A practical system for art-directing premium websites with AI, bespoke assets, image and video generation, precise prompting, GSAP, responsive motion, and production QA.

FREE EDITION | AUGUST 2026

The goal is not to make AI "look expensive." The goal is to run a small digital studio with enough taste, control and technical precision that AI becomes leverage instead of the art director.

POSITIONING NOTE

A \$5K-\$10K site is a market position, not an automatic price tag. Scope, strategy, portfolio strength, business outcomes, geography, sales ability and client trust all affect pricing. This guide focuses on the production system that makes premium positioning credible.

How to use this playbook

This guide is designed to be executed, not merely read. Work from the front of the pipeline to the back: reference intelligence first, then art direction, assets, motion, implementation, browser QA and client delivery.

- 1 Build a reference board from multiple sources and deconstruct what you actually like.
- 2 Write a distinct art-direction brief before asking an image model for assets.
- 3 Generate and refine assets until composition, orientation, texture and negative space are intentional.
- 4 Animate only the state changes the design needs. Do not add motion because the tool can.
- 5 Implement the interaction system in React/CSS/GSAP or an equivalent stack.
- 6 Write a precise implementation brief, organize approved assets in the project, and preserve every locked design decision.
- 7 Validate the real browser build across breakpoints, motion states, interactions, accessibility, and production preview.

The complete studio loop

```
REFERENCE INTELLIGENCE
|
ART DIRECTION + TASTE
|
ASSET GENERATION -> MAGNIFIC REFINEMENT
|
HIGGSFIELD / VIDEO MOTION ASSETS
|
REACT + CSS/SVG + GSAP/LENIS
|
ITERATION + RESPONSIVE POLISH
|
PRECISE IMPLEMENTATION BRIEF
|
PROJECT ASSET ORGANIZATION
|
BROWSER QA + CLIENT DELIVERY
```

The locked architecture

PART I - TASTE & DIRECTION

- 01 What makes a premium animated site
- 02 Build a reference intelligence system
- 03 Remix inspiration into an original direction
- 04 Set up the AI creative studio with MCP

PART II - ASSETS & MOTION

- 05 Engineer assets before code
- 06 Prompt visual assets precisely
- 07 Refine without destroying the asset
- 08 Turn stills into motion
- 09 Design the motion system before coding

PART III - IMPLEMENTATION

- 10 Build with GSAP and the right animation layer
- 11 Use SVG, shells, masks and hybrid controls
- 12 Treat responsive as art direction
- 13 Run a disciplined polish loop
- 14 Write implementation briefs that preserve the design

PART IV - SHIPPING & DELIVERY

- 15 Organize production assets inside the project
- 16 Run full browser QA before shipping
- 17 Turn the system into a client workflow
- 18 Final premium-site checklist

APPENDICES

- A Prompt templates
- B Reference decomposition worksheet
- C Current tool setup and official links
- D Glossary and final notes

What makes a premium animated site

Why generic AI output looks cheap even when the code is technically competent.

Premium work is not defined by the number of effects. It is defined by control. A high-end hero usually has a clear focal subject, deliberate negative space, intentional typography, a restrained material language and a motion narrative that helps the experience progress rather than merely decorate it.

THE GENERIC AI PATTERN

Centered headline. Gradient background. Floating glass cards. Generic pill buttons. Random fade-ups. Stock-like imagery. Desktop-first layout with mobile treated as a scale-down.

THE PREMIUM PATTERN

Art direction first. Bespoke assets. Strong hierarchy. Purposeful interactions. Exact responsive states. Measurable motion beats. Consistent materials. Clean implementation and validation.

The seven levers of perceived value

- **Art direction** - a coherent visual thesis that can be described in one sentence.
- **Asset control** - custom subjects, environments, transparent layers, frames and shells instead of placeholder graphics.
- **Composition** - focal point and copy occupy deliberately different territories.
- **Typography** - hierarchy, line breaks, tracking and rhythm are treated as design, not defaults.
- **Motion** - state changes are timed and mapped to a narrative.
- **Responsiveness** - desktop, tablet and mobile are composed as distinct states.
- **Implementation precision** - the browser reproduces the intended values instead of letting a model "make it similar."

RULE OF THUMB

If you can remove the hero image, swap the palette and rename the brand without changing the structure, you probably have a generic template - not an art-directed experience.

Build a reference intelligence system

Use Awwwards, Dribbble, Pinterest, GSAP showcases and open-source work as a library of principles - not a folder of pages to copy.

A premium site usually starts with references, but the professional skill is not collecting attractive screenshots. It is extracting useful design decisions from them. One reference may solve typography. Another may solve navigation. A third may solve the hero composition. A fourth may demonstrate a transition mechanic.

SOURCE	WHAT TO STUDY	DO NOT COPY
Awwwards / studio sites	Composition, pacing, page rhythm, motion hierarchy	Brand identity, distinctive assets, full page structure
Dribbble	Control treatments, cards, micro-UI, color relationships	Illustration or complete UI one-for-one
Pinterest	Photography, materials, lighting, editorial layouts, palettes	A copyrighted composition as the final asset
GSAP demos	Interaction mechanics, pinning, scrub behavior, masks	The exact demo styling and copy
Open-source sites	Implementation ideas, architecture, accessibility patterns	Identity, proprietary media, licenses you do not have

The reference decomposition matrix

REFERENCE
-> WHAT CAUGHT MY EYE?
-> WHY DOES IT WORK?
-> WHAT PRINCIPLE CAN I EXTRACT?
-> WHAT MUST I CHANGE?
-> WHERE DOES IT FIT IN MY OWN SYSTEM?

COPY PRINCIPLES, NOT IDENTITY

A composition principle, scroll mechanic or material treatment can inspire a new system. A finished brand, character, signature illustration or distinctive page should not be lifted wholesale. Transformation is part of the creative process, not a legal afterthought.

Remix inspiration into an original direction

Turn a pile of references into a single authored visual system.

Before generation or coding, write a one-page art-direction brief. The brief forces you to decide what belongs together and what does not. It is the filter that stops the project becoming a collage of unrelated references.

DECISION	EXAMPLE QUESTIONS
Identity	What is the brand trying to feel like: clinical, brutalist, cinematic, playful, technical, editorial?
Palette	How many accent colors exist? Which one carries signal and which ones stay neutral?
Type	What is display versus interface versus technical copy?
Geometry	Soft radii, sharp chamfers, circular cutouts, thin technical frames, full bleed?
Photography	Where is the subject? Which direction do they face? What light and lens language?
Motion personality	Elastic, mechanical, cinematic, editorial, high-frequency HUD, slow luxury?
Interaction	What does the pointer reveal, what does scroll advance, what opens on click?

A useful remix method is: Collect -> Deconstruct -> Select -> Transform -> Recombine -> Art-direct. If the result still looks like the original reference with a different logo, the transformation step was too weak.

YOUR TASTE IS THE CONTROL LAYER

AI can produce options at speed. It cannot decide which compromises are acceptable for your brand unless you teach the system what matters. Your job is selection, rejection and correction.

Set up the AI creative studio with MCP

Use an agent as the production console, then connect specialist media tools for generation and iteration.

Model Context Protocol (MCP) lets a compatible AI client call external tools inside the same working session. For a creative workflow, that means the conversation can move from art direction to image generation, refinement, video generation and implementation without repeatedly rebuilding context.

Magnific MCP - current setup

- 1 Open your MCP-compatible client and go to its Connectors/Apps area.
- 2 Add Magnific from the connector directory where available, or add the endpoint manually: <https://mcp.magnific.com>
- 3 Authenticate with your Magnific account and approve the requested permissions.
- 4 Ask the agent to generate, edit, relight or upscale an asset, then iterate on the same selected result instead of restarting from zero.

CURRENT PRODUCT NOTE

Magnific states that MCP is available on paid plans and MCP actions consume credits. Its documentation lists Claude, ChatGPT, Cursor, Codex, VS Code, Gemini and other compatible clients. Verify the latest plan/UI before publishing a tutorial because connector menus can change.

Higgsfield MCP / CLI - current setup

- 1 For MCP, add a custom connector named Higgsfield with: <https://mcp.higgsfield.ai/mcp>
- 2 Authenticate through your Higgsfield account. The official MCP flow does not require a separate API key.
- 3 For Claude Code or other terminal-first workflows, the current CLI path is: `npm i -g @higgsfield/cli`, then `higgsfield auth login`, then `npx skills add higgsfield-ai/skills`.
- 4 Use prior generations as references so the agent can refine or animate a selected asset rather than generating disconnected variants.

CHATGPT AVAILABILITY

Full custom MCP/app support in ChatGPT is plan/workspace dependent and continues to evolve. As of Aug 2026, OpenAI documents full MCP support for Business and Enterprise/Edu on web. If a client cannot add the connector, use a supported MCP client such as Claude/Claude Code, Cursor, Codex or another compatible environment.

The correct agent loop

```
DIRECT THE AGENT
-> GENERATE 3-5 CONTROLLED DIRECTIONS
-> SELECT ONE
-> IDENTIFY THE SPECIFIC FAILURE
-> REFINE ONLY THAT FAILURE
-> APPROVE THE ASSET
-> ANIMATE THE APPROVED ASSET
-> IMPLEMENT IT IN THE SITE
```


Engineer assets before code

The strongest AI sites are designed around controlled visual inputs, not code-generated placeholders.

Treat every critical hero asset as production material. Decide what role it plays in the DOM, what crop it needs, which areas must remain quiet for copy, whether transparency is required and whether a separate mobile treatment is necessary.

ASSET TYPE	ENGINEERING QUESTION
Hero background	Where is the focal subject? Is the copy area protected? Does mobile need a different crop?
Character / product layer	Does it need alpha? What is its center axis? What must never be mirrored or regenerated?
Poster frame	Does it match the first video frame and prevent a black flash?
Shell / frame artwork	Will live HTML sit on top? Must the asset stretch, fill, mask or clip inside a fixed box?
Texture / ornament	Can it be procedural CSS/SVG instead of another request?
Video clip	Is it designed for autoplay, normal playback or currentTime scrubbing?

Asset acceptance checklist

- Composition matches the intended website role, not merely a pretty standalone image.
- Subject orientation is correct and leaves deliberate negative space.
- Face/product identity survives enhancement and animation.
- Transparency edges are clean and not haloed.
- Lighting direction and color temperature match adjacent assets.
- Desktop and mobile crops have been tested in a browser-shaped frame.
- No unlicensed font, logo, stock image or proprietary visual is being redistributed.

Prompt visual assets precisely

Structure prompts like a production specification rather than an adjective pile.

A useful prompt is hierarchical. Put identity and composition first because those are the expensive things to correct later. Lighting, materials and texture come after the image is structurally right.

IDENTITY

Exact subject / product / role.

COMPOSITION

Placement, orientation, negative space, crop, aspect ratio.

CAMERA

Framing, lens feel, perspective, camera height.

LIGHTING

Direction, softness, key/fill/rim, color temperature.

MATERIALS

Surface behavior: matte ceramic, brushed metal, real skin, leather, glass.

WEBSITE ROLE

Hero background, transparent foreground layer, card image, poster, etc.

PRESERVE

Elements that may not move or change.

DO NOT

Specific failure modes: no mirrored subject, no extra jewelry, no text, no oversharpening.

Iteration discipline

Do not rewrite the entire prompt after every defect. If composition is correct and texture is wrong, preserve composition and correct texture. If identity is correct and the subject is facing the wrong direction, fix orientation without reopening color, clothing and environment. Iteration becomes faster when each pass has one job.

PROMPTING IS NOT THE SAME AS ART DIRECTION

The prompt describes constraints. Art direction is the judgment that decides which constraints matter, which generation is usable and what must be rejected.

Refine without destroying the asset

Use Magnific or another enhancer as a controlled finishing pass, not a creative reset.

Enhancement should increase believability while preserving the approved composition. The common failure is an enhancer that makes the image superficially sharper but changes the face, invents texture or pushes everything into synthetic CGI crispness.

- 1

Lock the composition first. Do not enhance a structurally wrong image.
- 2

Identify a measurable defect: skin texture, material micro-detail, edge quality, lighting realism, local blur or aliasing.
- 3

Use a conservative refinement pass with explicit preservation instructions.
- 4

Compare against the approved source at the same crop. Check face, silhouette, negative space and object position before checking detail.
- 5

Reject overprocessed outputs. A more detailed image is not automatically a more realistic image.

CHECK	FAILURE SIGNAL
Identity	Face shape, eyes, hairstyle or product silhouette changed
Composition	Crop, camera height or subject position drifted
Texture	Skin turns waxy; metal becomes plastic; wood becomes noise
Edges	Transparent edges halo or gain unwanted sharpening
Lighting	Rim/key direction changes and no longer matches the scene
Detail	Fake micro-text, random seams, invented hardware or excessive pores

Turn stills into motion

Animate the state change the website needs, not a generic cinematic shot.

A website motion asset is constrained by the UI. If the hero needs copy on the left, the video must protect that space throughout the transition. If the scroll story ends on a different visual state, the final frame must land where the UI expects it.

USE CASE	MOTION BRIEF
Subtle living hero	Micro head/eye/environment motion; camera largely locked; seamless visual continuity
Scroll-scrub transformation	Clear chronological state change with stable subject identity and no sudden camera cuts
Character reveal	Preserve center axis; transition only the intended layer or pose
Product hero	Controlled orbit or material reveal; no framing drift that breaks overlay UI
Green-screen / keyed asset	Consistent subject, clean background, no spill on edges, minimal camera translation

Example Higgsfield-style direction

Use the approved reference image as the identity and composition anchor.
Keep the camera nearly locked. Preserve the subject on the right third for the entire clip.
Animate a restrained 6-second progression: neutral gaze -> subtle light activation -> controlled head/eye movement -> final resolved state.
Do not change clothing, face, lens perspective, background layout or aspect ratio.
No hard cuts. No text. No extra objects. The final frame must remain compatible with left-aligned hero copy.

FIRST/LAST FRAME THINKING

Before generating motion, define what frame 0 and the final frame must accomplish for the interface. This makes the video an asset in a system, not a standalone clip.

Design the motion system before coding

Map states, transitions and interface reactions onto normalized progress.

Premium motion feels intentional because multiple layers respond to the same narrative. A pinned hero can treat scroll as a normalized timeline from 0 to 1, then map video time, copy, theme, cards, navigation and progress UI to that shared progress.

0.00	0.20	0.50	0.78	1.00
ARRIVAL	REVEAL	TRANSFORM	PROOF/CARDS	RESOLUTION
video	copy out	theme shift	cards in	handoff
copy 1	copy 2	proof in	CTA in	nav state

Do not start by asking, "What animations can I add?" Start by asking, "What state is the user in now, what state comes next, and what should visually communicate that transition?"

- Use one source of truth for scroll progress where possible.
- Define transition windows before tuning easing.
- Keep the number of simultaneous hero systems understandable.
- Avoid animation that fights the focal subject or moves copy across the face/product.
- Design the final unpin/handoff state so the page does not feel like it simply stops.

Build with GSAP and the right animation layer

Use the simplest system that can reproduce the choreography precisely.

CSS transitions and keyframes are excellent for deterministic micro-motion. GSAP becomes valuable when several elements need coordinated timelines, precise control, pointer smoothing or scroll-linked state. ScrollTrigger supports trigger-based animation, pinning and scrubbed timelines; its numeric scrub option adds catch-up smoothing between scrollbar and playhead.

PROBLEM	GOOD DEFAULT
Simple hover / focus / loader pulse	CSS transition or keyframes
Component state animation	CSS or a framework motion layer
Complex timeline choreography	GSAP Timeline
Pinned scroll narrative	GSAP ScrollTrigger
Smooth pointer following	GSAP quickTo / ticker
3D rendering requirement	Three.js/WebGL only if the design genuinely needs a renderer

Scroll architecture pattern

```
gsap.registerPlugin(ScrollTrigger)

const tl = gsap.timeline({
  scrollTrigger: {
    trigger: hero,
    start: "top top",
    end: () => "+=" + window.innerHeight * N,
    pin: true,
    scrub: 1,
    invalidateOnRefresh: true
  }
})

// Add state transitions to the timeline.
// Clean up the GSAP context / trigger on unmount.
```

DO NOT ANIMATE THE PINNED CONTAINER BLINDLY

Pin geometry is measurement-sensitive. Animate children inside the pinned area unless you understand how transforming the pinned element affects ScrollTrigger calculations.

Use SVG, shells, masks and hybrid controls

Premium controls often combine authored artwork with live semantic HTML.

A button does not have to be either an image or CSS. A strong hybrid control can use a transparent generated shell underneath a live label and live SVG arrow. The shell provides the unique material treatment; HTML preserves accessibility, responsive typography and interaction.

BUTTON / CARD STACK

1. Supplied shell / frame artwork
2. Image or material layer
3. Directional fade / readability mask
4. Sheen / highlight
5. Rim / border / SVG outline
6. Live HTML content + semantic control
7. GSAP/CSS interaction state

- Keep exact SVG viewBox and path data when the geometry is part of the design.
- Do not replace a measured chamfer with a generic rounded rectangle.
- Use masks/clip-paths when reveal geometry is interaction-critical.
- Keep live labels out of raster assets when they need to remain accessible and responsive.
- If a supplied shell intentionally uses object-fit: fill inside a fixed box, do not "correct" it to contain.

WHY THIS MATTERS

When a coding model hears "make a luxury glass button," it invents a new design. When it receives the actual shell plus exact HTML/SVG structure, visual inference drops dramatically.

Treat responsive as art direction

Mobile is a different composition, not desktop squeezed into less width.

Responsive fidelity is one of the fastest ways to tell whether a premium site is truly designed. The focal subject, copy block, controls and motion density often need different rules across desktop, tablet and mobile.

STATE	DECISIONS TO LOCK
Large desktop	Max clamps, media quality, copy width, decoration density, wide nav
Desktop	Fluid spacing, focal point, pointer behavior, pin distance
Tablet	Desktop vs mobile motion branch, crop changes, control visibility
Mobile	Different media/crop, copy anchoring, simplified HUD, card scroller
Short height	What compresses? What must stay visible? Does the source intentionally have no height breakpoint?

Test both sides of every meaningful breakpoint. If 768 is desktop and 767 is mobile, validate both. If 640 is a hybrid state and 639 is compact mobile, validate both. A one-pixel boundary can change source selection, control visibility or motion architecture.

THE FOCAL-POINT TEST

At every viewport, draw an imaginary exclusion zone around the face/product. Important copy and controls should not collide with it unless the art direction explicitly intends that overlap.

Run a disciplined polish loop

Iteration is part of premium work. The goal is controlled convergence, not endless tweaking.

A useful review loop is visual and measurable. Capture the site at a fixed viewport, compare it with the intended state, identify the largest mismatch and change only the subsystem that caused it.

- 1

Capture the exact viewport and state.
- 2

List mismatches by category: geometry, asset, type, color, motion, interaction, responsive, network.
- 3

Choose the highest-impact mismatch. Do not change five systems at once.
- 4

Implement a narrow correction.
- 5

Re-run the same viewport/state and compare again.
- 6

Only after visual parity, run console/network/build checks.

PASS	QUESTIONS
Visual	Are subject position, scale, crop, layers, type and gradients correct?
Motion	Are state windows, delays, eases and scrub behavior correct?
Interaction	Do menu, cursor, hover, CTA and keyboard states behave correctly?
Responsive	Are breakpoint branches and mobile media correct?
Technical	No console warnings, 404s, rejected promises, overflow or build failures?

Write implementation briefs that preserve the design

Give the coding agent a production specification, not a pile of adjectives.

Once the art direction, assets and motion states are approved, translate those decisions into a structured implementation brief. The objective is to make the build predictable inside one project. Exact values should be stated explicitly so the coding agent is solving implementation rather than re-designing the page.

Scope & hierarchy	Exact Hero boundary, DOM/component responsibilities, visible copy, and what must not be invented.
Assets & visual rules	Local project paths, dimensions, crop/focal rules, transparency, typography, colors, gradients, shells, masks, and SVG geometry.
Motion & responsive	State map, GSAP/ScrollTrigger/Lenis values, breakpoints, mobile branches, reduced motion, interactions, and required viewport tests.

THE NO-INVENTION RULE

If a concrete value already exists - a breakpoint, transform, SVG path, timing, gradient, crop, line break, or easing - write it into the implementation brief. Do not ask the coding model to “make something similar” when the design decision is already known.

What belongs in a strong implementation brief

- Clear scope: what is part of the Hero and what is outside the task.
- Exact visual tokens: colors, type, spacing, gradients, masks, crop rules and responsive breakpoints.
- Exact motion architecture: state windows, GSAP/ScrollTrigger/Lenis constants, easing, sequencing and cleanup.
- Exact DOM/SVG/icon geometry and visible/accessibility copy when those details are design-critical.
- Stable local asset paths and a simple asset map so components never guess which file belongs where.
- Explicit negative constraints: what must not be added, simplified, mirrored, recolored, reflowed or substituted.
- A validation matrix covering desktop, tablet, mobile, interactions, console/build health and final motion states.

Organize production assets inside the project

Keep critical media obvious, local and role-based so the implementation stays predictable.

For most client sites, approved Hero media can live directly in the project. Use stable semantic names and a simple folder convention so the implementation is self-contained. In Vite, large files that need stable root URLs can live under `public/assets`, while smaller imported assets can live under `src/assets` when bundler processing is useful.

```
public/assets/  
  hero/  
    background-desktop.webp  
    background-mobile.webp  
    hero-poster.webp  
    hero-scroll.mp4  
    subject-transparent.webp  
  shared/  
    brand-mark.webp  
    navigation-shell.webp
```

Name assets by role, not by generation history. A component should be able to request “hero-poster.webp” or “navigation-shell.webp” without knowing which AI tool or iteration produced it.

Asset preparation sequence

- 1 Give approved files semantic names and place them in Hero/shared folders before wiring components.
- 2 Keep the original master separately; use the approved deployment copy in the project without accidental recompression.
- 3 Verify intrinsic dimensions, aspect ratio, alpha, orientation and focal point before implementation.
- 4 For scrubbed MP4s, keep a poster frame, browser-friendly H.264 delivery, front-loaded metadata/faststart, and test seeking in the built site.
- 5 Preload only truly critical above-the-fold media; avoid duplicate requests caused by mismatched preload and rendered paths.
- 6 Run the production build and preview it. Confirm every asset path works outside the development server.

KEEP THE PROJECT SELF-CONTAINED

The design guide does not require a separate asset-hosting layer. Store approved media in the repository using predictable paths, then let the normal deployment platform serve the built site. The important part is asset fidelity, naming, preload discipline, and browser behavior.

PART IV - SHIPPING & DELIVERY

16

Run full browser QA before shipping

A premium site is not finished when one screenshot looks right.

Validate the actual browser experience: first load, motion, responsive branches, menus, hover/focus states, video seeking, asset loading, console health and the production build. Re-test the same viewport after every meaningful correction so polish becomes measurable rather than subjective.

- QA ORDER
- 1 Initial load and loader/poster state
 - 2 Hero motion from start to final handoff
 - 3 Breakpoint edges and mobile composition
 - 4 Menu, cursor, CTA, hover, focus and keyboard states
 - 5 Asset loading, video seeking and performance sanity
 - 6 Production build + preview

Evaluation matrix

Build	Production build completes with no missing imports or broken asset paths.
Assets	All required local media load from the built site; correct image/video dimensions and no duplicate critical requests.
Console	No errors, warnings, unhandled promise rejections or avoidable React/runtime noise.
Desktop	Composition, motion, typography and interactions match the intended large-screen state.
Mobile	Correct crop, controls, line breaks, motion branch and no unintended document-level overflow.
Motion	Pin/scrub/transition windows, video frames, menu motion and final handoff land on the intended states.
Accessibility	Keyboard, focus, reduced-motion behavior, semantic controls and readable text remain usable.

FIX THE SYSTEM, NOT THE SCREENSHOT
When a mismatch appears, trace it to the responsible system - crop, spacing, typography, breakpoint, asset, timeline or interaction. Correct the source rule and re-test the same state instead of piling on viewport-specific patches.

Turn the system into a client workflow

Use the same production discipline whether the project is a portfolio experiment or paid delivery.

- 1 Discovery: clarify business goal, audience, constraints, content and success metric.
- 2 Reference direction: agree on visual principles, not a site to clone.
- 3 Art direction: lock palette, type, composition, motion personality and responsive priorities.
- 4 Hero concept: create the first-view system early because it sets the visual standard.
- 5 Asset production: generate, refine, license-check and approve critical visual inputs.
- 6 Implementation: build the layout and interaction architecture with clean ownership boundaries.
- 7 Responsive and polish: validate exact viewport states and interactions.
- 8 Technical QA: build, console, network, accessibility and performance checks.
- 9 Delivery: deployment, source handoff, documented assets/licensing and change scope.

The \$5K-\$10K positioning becomes easier to defend when the process itself looks like a studio: documented decisions, deliberate assets, controlled review, clean implementation and predictable delivery. Flashy motion alone is not a business outcome.

SELL THE SYSTEM, NOT THE TOOL LIST

Clients do not need to buy "GSAP + AI." They buy a distinctive, credible digital experience that supports their brand, campaign or conversion objective. The tools are how you deliver it efficiently.

Final premium-site checklist

A compact pre-flight you can use before publishing, presenting or handing the site to a client.

ART DIRECTION

- ☐ One-sentence visual thesis is clear
- ☐ Palette and type have defined roles
- ☐ Reference influences have been transformed into an original system

ASSETS

- ☐ Subject orientation and negative space are deliberate
- ☐ Critical assets are approved at real browser crops
- ☐ Transparent edges and materials survive enhancement
- ☐ Rights/licenses permit the intended use

MOTION

- ☐ Every animation has a narrative purpose
- ☐ State windows are defined and testable
- ☐ No arbitrary effects fight the focal subject
- ☐ Reduced-motion behavior matches the intended/source contract

RESPONSIVE

- ☐ Desktop, tablet and mobile are independently composed
- ☐ Both sides of material breakpoints are tested
- ☐ No important copy overlaps the focal subject
- ☐ No unintended page-level horizontal overflow

TECHNICAL

- ☐ Production build passes
- ☐ Console is clean
- ☐ Asset paths, dimensions, preload behavior and video/poster pairing are correct
- ☐ Video scrub media supports seeking/ranges where required
- ☐ Cleanup removes listeners, tickers, observers and triggers

DELIVERY

- ☐ Approved assets are organized with stable semantic project paths
- ☐ Implementation brief contains the exact visual, motion and responsive decisions
- ☐ Browser QA passes at required viewport and interaction states
- ☐ Production build/preview matches development behavior

THE STANDARD

The target is not perfection by intuition. The target is a repeatable process where important decisions are explicit, assets are controlled, behavior is measurable and the final implementation can survive context loss.

APPENDIX A

Prompt templates

Use these as structures. Replace the placeholders with the specifics of the project; do not treat them as magic incantations.

1. Reference-to-art-direction prompt

I am building a premium [CATEGORY] website.
Analyze the references I provide as separate design systems, not as pages to clone.
For each reference, extract: composition, typography, material language, interaction, motion, lighting and navigation ideas.
Then propose 3 original art directions that recombine principles from multiple references while changing identity, palette, copy, assets, hierarchy and layout enough to create a distinct result.
Explain what is borrowed as a principle and what is intentionally transformed.

2. Image asset prompt skeleton

ROLE: [hero background / transparent foreground / card image]
IDENTITY: [subject/product]
COMPOSITION: [exact side, crop, negative space]
CAMERA: [framing/lens/perspective]
LIGHTING: [direction, softness, temperature]
MATERIALS: [realistic surface behavior]
WEBSITE PLACEMENT: [where copy/UI must remain clear]
PRESERVE: [identity/orientation/clothing/logo/geometry]
DO NOT: [mirror, add text, sharpen, invent objects, change crop, etc.]

3. Refinement prompt

Preserve the exact composition, crop, subject identity, pose, camera angle and lighting direction of the selected image.
Improve only: [specific defect].
Keep materials photographic and restrained. Do not over-sharpen, invent micro-detail, alter facial structure, move objects or change the background layout.
Return a refined version that can replace the source asset without requiring layout changes.

4. Motion asset prompt

Use the approved still as the composition and identity anchor.
Animate this website state change over [duration]: [state A] -> [state B].
Keep [subject] in the same screen territory for the entire clip so [left/right] UI remains unobstructed.
Preserve identity, wardrobe/product geometry, camera perspective and aspect ratio.
No cuts, no extra objects, no text. The final frame must satisfy: [final UI requirement].

5. Coding implementation brief

Implement the supplied art direction as an exact first-view system.
Treat assets, breakpoint rules, copy, SVG geometry, animation constants and interaction behavior as authoritative.

Do not redesign or genericize.
Use the smallest animation stack capable of reproducing the choreography.
Validate build, console, network, responsive states and reduced-motion behavior before completion.

APPENDIX B

Reference decomposition worksheet

REFERENCE	WHAT I LIKE	WHY IT WORKS	HOW I TRANSFORM IT
1			
2			
3			
4			
5			

Art-direction synthesis

Visual thesis: _____

Palette: _____

Display type: _____

UI/technical type: _____

Subject & camera: _____

Material language: _____

Motion personality: _____

Hero interaction: _____

Mobile strategy: _____

Explicit exclusions: _____

Current tool setup & official links

These details were verified against official documentation in August 2026. Interfaces, plans and product capabilities can change, so re-check the linked docs before publishing a step-by-step tutorial.

TOOL	ENDPOINT / COMMAND	NOTE
Magnific MCP	https://mcp.magnific.com	Official docs say MCP is available on paid plans; MCP actions consume credits.
Higgsfield MCP	https://mcp.higgsfield.ai/mcp	Authenticate with your Higgsfield account; no separate API key required for the MCP flow.
Higgsfield CLI	<code>npm i -g @higgsfield/cli</code>	Then higgsfield auth login; companion skills: <code>npx skills add higgsfield-ai/skills</code> .
GSAP ScrollTrigger	https://gsap.com/docs/v3/Plugins/ScrollTrigger/	Official docs for pin, scrub, refresh, cleanup and ScrollTrigger options.
Vite static asset handling	https://vite.dev/guide/assets.html	Official Vite guidance for imported assets and files served from public/.
ChatGPT custom MCP/apps	https://help.openai.com/en/articles/12584461	Full custom MCP support is plan/workspace dependent and evolving.

Official references: [Magnific MCP](#) [Higgsfield MCP](#) [Higgsfield CLI](#) [GSAP ScrollTrigger](#) [Vite Static Assets](#) [OpenAI MCP apps](#)

Glossary & final notes

TERM	MEANING
Art direction	The coherent visual and behavioral thesis that controls what belongs in the project.
Negative space	Deliberately quiet image territory reserved for copy/UI.
MCP	Model Context Protocol: a standard for connecting an AI client to external tools/services.
Implementation brief	A structured build specification that locks scope, assets, visual values, motion, responsive rules and validation before coding.
Asset map	A simple list of approved project media, semantic local paths, roles, dimensions and preservation rules.
Scroll scrub	An animation or media playhead mapped to scroll progress rather than normal playback.
Pin	Keeping a section fixed while the page consumes additional scroll distance.
QA pass	A repeatable browser/build validation run across required viewports, motion states, interactions, assets and accessibility.
Focal exclusion zone	Area around a face/product that important copy should not cross without deliberate intent.

FINAL PRINCIPLE

AI is most powerful when you remove unnecessary manual repetition without removing judgment. Keep taste, selection, licensing, accessibility and final accountability in the human loop.

Build the system once. Then make each new site a controlled variation of a proven production pipeline - not another improvisation from zero.

REFERENCE → TASTE → ASSETS → MOTION → CODE → VALIDATION

The premium difference is control.